

NT36 Enrichment

†1. **Prodigal Young Woman at a ‘Dude Ranch’ near Jackson Hole, Wyoming:** “Many years ago a young lady shared this experience with me. *She is a remarkable disciple, and her life has come to typify the highest levels of Christian conduct and goodness, but for a time in junior high and high school, she strayed from the straight and narrow path and became lost like the prodigal son.*

“Following her high school experiences, she traveled to Wyoming to work for a summer on a “Dude Ranch” near Jackson Hole. Her parents were not pleased to have her so far away, but both recognized that their major function at that time was to extend love and support. Even though she had been continually willing to talk to them, to admit her transgressions and weaknesses, she had ceased being willing to listen to their counsel. And so she went.

“...
“One evening she left the girls' dorm at the ranch. She was on the way to the Wranglers' dormitory--the dormitory where the young men employed by the ranch made their summer homes. She knew as she walked along that what she intended to do she should not do, and a part of her did not want to go on. But another, and usually stronger part, did. She told me that as she walked, she began to pray: ‘Heavenly Father, why don't you stop me.’

“And she got an answer. A message came clearly to her heart, a message something like this: ‘Daughter, I can't stop you. But if you will stop yourself, and turn around, I will help you.’

“She was so surprised by this unexpected response that she stopped walking. (She described this to me in great detail.) She said, “I stopped, and then slowly turned around until I was facing back the way I had come. And for the first time in months, perhaps years, I felt the Spirit in my heart. It was as though the Father was by my side. I began to walk to back to my own room, and I was not alone.” It was at that moment that her life began to change. As soon as she turned around and started home, “[her] Father saw [her], and had compassion, and ran, and fell on [her] neck, and kissed [her].” (Luke 15:20) He then made the journey home by her side. (Ted L. Gibbons, “[New Testament Lesson 18: He Was Lost and Is Found](#),” at LDS Living.com; accessed Sept. 24, 2015.)

†2. *The Life and Teachings of Jesus and His Apostles*
Introduction: Romans

It had been more than twenty years since Paul had started on the road to what he thought would lead him only to Damascus but which, instead, began a far longer and more glorious journey. He had left Jerusalem that day seeing but blind; he had come to Damascus blind but seeing. When he had set out, he had in his hand the

edict of the high priest: bind the followers of the way and bring them to the prisons of Jerusalem. When he had arrived, he had in his heart the edict of Christ: unbind the gentiles and bring them to the mansions of the heavenly Jerusalem. For more than seven thousand days now, the man from Tarsus had labored to fulfill that edict. He had crossed and recrossed eight or more provinces of the Roman empire. He had personally established a number of branches of the church. His converts must have numbered well into the thousands. He had been beaten, stoned, scourged, jailed, and shipwrecked and had endured hunger, thirst, cold, fatigue, rejection, insults, scorn, and desertion—and all this while afflicted with his own “thorn in the flesh.” Surely now he had done enough? Surely now he could return to Jerusalem and pass the baton on to younger hands?

But of course such would be unthinkable to Paul. With characteristic simplicity Luke reports, “After these things were ended, Paul purposed in the spirit . . . to go to Jerusalem, saying, After I have been there, I must also see Rome.” (Acts 19:21.) And so he had come to Corinth to spend the winter, waiting for safe sailing weather. It must have been a time of reflection and planning and concern. It was evidently during these months that reports arrived saying that Galatia was being ravaged by the onslaughts of the Judaizers. “True righteousness is based in the law of Moses,” they were saying, “Believing in Christ is all well and good, but you must not leave the foundation principles of circumcision, dietary law, and Levitical ritual.” They maligned Paul and his office, wooing many away from the teachings of the great apostle.

Paul had written to the churches in Galatia and sharply condemned the false teachings. “O foolish Galatians, who hath bewitched you?” he asked in sorrow. (Galatians 3:1.) It was shortly after this that the apostle wrote his letter to Rome, alerting the saints there of his intent to visit them. The reports from Rome were positive. The saints were believing, growing, testifying. But the concern for the growing threat of the false teachers must still have weighed heavily on his mind, for the book of Romans contains Paul's powerful defense of true righteousness and his rejection of any system of salvation that is not based on faith in Jesus Christ.

How ironic that the letters to Rome and Galatia should be used in later centuries as the basis for the doctrine that works are unessential for salvation. Can you imagine the retort of the man who had been five times scourged of the Jews to those who would say that all you must do to be saved is confess with your mouth that Jesus is the Christ? Can you picture the response of the man who for two decades had devoted his life to good works to those who say that good works are not a requirement for salvation? But on the other hand, you must also recognize that Paul rejected the idea fostered by the Judaizers, namely, that man can achieve

righteousness by his own efforts. The ideas are opposite ends of the grace and works continuum, but both are false. In order to find the true middle ground, let us now turn to a careful study of what Paul wrote to the saints in Rome. What is the proper relationship between our own works and the grace of God? If a man is justified by faith, just what does that mean? As you study this lesson and ponder such questions, remember Paul the man. Remember the experiences that had molded and shaped him as he sat in Corinth and wrote his letter to the saints in Rome.

†3. (39-3) What Are Some of the Significant Contributions of Romans?

“Romans defines the gospel and summarizes the laws by obedience to which full salvation comes. It speaks plainly of Adam’s fall, which brought death, and Christ’s atoning sacrifice, which brought life. It tells how the law of justification works, how men are justified by faith and works, through the blood of Christ. In it are some of the most explicit Biblical teachings on the election of grace, the status of the chosen race, on why salvation cannot come by the law of Moses alone, on why circumcision was done away in Christ, and on how and why salvation was taken to the Gentiles. And it is a chief source of the glorious doctrine of joint-heirship with Christ, that marvelous principle under which men, through celestial marriage and the continuation of the family unit in eternity, can gain exaltation in the highest celestial heaven. . . .

“In its very nature Romans is an epistle capable of differing interpretations. Those without prior and full knowledge of the doctrines involved find it exceedingly difficult to place Paul’s comments about these doctrines into their true perspective. For instance, it is on a misunderstanding of the Apostle’s statement about justification by faith alone that the whole sectarian world is led to believe that men are not required to work out their own salvation; and it was this very passage that enabled Martin Luther to justify in his own mind his break with Catholicism, an eventuality of vital importance to the furtherance of the Lord’s work on earth.” (McConkie, DNTC, 2:212–13.)

†4. “In the ‘Bluebird’: “In the ‘Bluebird’ Maeterlinck pictures unborn children summoned to earth life. As one group approaches the earth, the voices of the children earthward tending are heard in the distance to cry: ‘The earth! the earth! I can see it; how beautiful it is! . . .’ Then following these cries of ecstasy, there issued from out of the depth of the abyss a sweet song of gentleness and expectancy, in reference to which the author says: ‘It is the song of the mothers coming out to meet them.’

“Maeterlinck’s fairy play is not all fantasy or imagination, neither is Wordsworth’s ‘Ode on Intimations of Immortality’ wherein he says:

*Our birth is but a sleep and a forgetting,
The Soul that rises with us, our life’s Star;
Hath had elsewhere its setting
And cometh from afar;
Not in entire forgetfulness,
And not in utter nakedness
But trailing clouds of glory do we come
From God, who is our home.*

(David O. McKay, as cited by Harold B. Lee, Address to BYU Sixth Stake, 27 Apr. 1969, p. 20.)

†4. “The Trouble with Maria,” *Ensign*, Mormon Journal, August 1982, By Kathryn Malmfeldt

Instead of asking the noisemakers to leave, Maria invited them into our group.

Maria had been a member of the Church for only two years when we met in Panama, where our husbands were both stationed in the army. A dark-eyed and beautiful Mexican girl, Maria spoke English only haltingly. We long-time members tried to lend her a hand; we felt it was our duty to help her get settled into her new life.

The trouble with Maria was that she believed in following every commandment literally.

“Maria,” we explained, “the prophet did counsel us to be free of debt. But the sky won’t fall down on you if you have car payments.”

But Maria worked hard and prayed and budgeted. In a few months her family owned the station wagon they had needed—and they paid cash for it.

And that big quote from Church leaders: “Every member a missionary.” We tried to convince Maria that she needed to understand the quote in its proper context—that it referred to being an example to others, that we didn’t necessarily have to start conversations about the Church with our friends.

But that’s not the way Maria understood it. She introduced herself to new friends in the first sentence, stated her religion in the second, and asked, “Would you like to know more?” in the third. And she gave more referrals to the missionaries than anyone else in our branch.

Maria was a firm believer in personal revelation. She believed we could all be guided by the Spirit.

“Well . . . yes, Maria, that’s true,” we explained. “But that doesn’t always mean we’re going to have visions or anything like that. It’s more like having an untroubled conscience or a calm feeling,” we said.

But one day, Maria was blessed to see in her mind a picture of herself bearing her testimony, something she had never done before. The next morning our branch went to a popular beach for an outing. A short distance around the cove, another branch was having a baptismal service, and Maria felt prompted to join them. Upon seeing Maria join the group, the missionary in charge of

the service announced that they would now be privileged to hear the testimony of Sister Maria. Maria wept, for the revelation she had experienced was fulfilled.

On another occasion, our branch was gathered at a lake for two baptisms. One of the converts and a missionary stood in the water about to proceed with the ordinance when a noisy family walked by, laughing and shouting.

None of us had as good a command of the Spanish language as Maria did, so we asked her to tell them to be quiet. "Maria," we urged, "ask them to go somewhere else."

But instead, Maria invited the noisemakers into our group. Quiet now, the family watched both baptisms while she explained the details and our beliefs. Afterward, they invited the missionaries to their home. They accepted the baptismal challenge a few weeks later.

Maria read in the Bible: "Cast thy bread upon the waters." (Eccl. 11:1.) In Maria's case it was enchiladas, rice, and frijoles. And she took every opportunity to invite others to her home to partake.

"But Maria," we said, "you hardly have enough money to feed your own family. You can't invite others, too."

But even as we scolded, a neighbor would drop by with ten dollars. Or Maria would find some money on the roadside.

That was Maria. She has moved from our branch now; and we who tried so hard to educate her have lost a great teacher.

[illustration] Illustrated by Scott Snow

Kathryn Malmfeldt, mother of two children, is a Primary teacher and branch pianist in the Margarita Branch, Costa Rica San Jose Mission.

†5. President Marion G. Romney: "If we would avoid adopting the evils of the world, we must pursue a course which will daily feed our minds with and call them back to the things of the Spirit. I know of no better way to do this than by daily reading the Book of Mormon.

In all dispensations, the Lord has counseled His people to keep in their minds and thoughts the truths He has revealed to them. To the early Saints of this dispensation He said: "Let the solemnities of eternity rest upon your minds" ([D&C 43:34](#)). This counsel followed His statement to the elders:

"Ye are not sent forth to be taught, but to teach the children of men the things which I have put into your hands by the power of my Spirit:

"And ye are to be taught from on high" ([D&C 43:15-16](#))....

"Search the scriptures" (John 5:39), said Jesus to His carping critics, who, being surfeited with the things of

this world, rejected Him. In the scriptures they could, if they would, learn the truth about Him and the things of eternal life which He taught them." ("The Book of Mormon," *Ensign*, August 2005)

†6. I Am a Child of God – Video Links:

([I Am a Child of God: the original \(not remix\)](#))

([I Am a Child of God – Children's Choir](#))

([I Am a Child of God – Gladys Knight](#))

([I Am a Child of God – Mormon Messages](#))

†7. President Joseph Fielding Smith: "There are too many members of the Church who will not separate themselves from the figurative 'flesh-pots of Egypt'; too many who will not heed the counsels that are given in the revelations of the Lord, notwithstanding the magnitude of the promised blessings. There have been some who feel, as President John Taylor expressed it, 'who think that they can slide into the kingdom of God,' without complying with the commandments. By this he meant that they expect to receive the blessings of the exaltation because their names are still on the records of the Church: but they have not prepared themselves by active participation in faithful performance of duty." (*Answers to Gospel Questions*, 2: xii)

†8. Elder Neal A. Maxwell: "Pride, not meekness, leads to exclusionary hobbies within the Church or the gospel. Hobbies can give an individual a sense of preeminence, a cause to be lifted up. There are those in the Church, unfortunately, who like such an edge. Some such persons resist counsel concerning how they are missing the balancing dimensions of the gospel. Having conscientiously and effectively pursued a particular doctrine or portion of the gospel, they may, in fact, have unusual knowledge in that particular thing. (Alma 32:34.) For them, however, ... what has been acquired becomes a coveted source of pride." (*Meek and Lowly*, 63)

†9. Elder Benjamin De Hoyos: "To the degree that members of the Church live the gospel and follow the counsel of the prophets, they will, little by little and even without noticing it, become sanctified. Humble members of the Church who conduct daily family prayer and scripture study, engage in family history, and consecrate their time to worship in the temple frequently, become Saints. They are those who are dedicated to creating eternal families. They are also those who set apart time from their busy lives to rescue those who have become alienated from the Church and encourage them to return and sit at the Lord's table. They are those elders and sisters and mature couples who respond to a call to serve as the Lord's missionaries. Yes, my brothers and sisters, they become Saints to the degree that they discover that warm and wonderful feeling that is called charity, or the

pure love of Christ (see [Moroni 7:42-48](#)).” (“[Called to Be Saints](#),” *Ensign*, May 2011.

†10. **Army Infantry Mud:** “I continued to work my way forward, forcing my way down through the yielding mud until my descent was stopped by the firmness of earth not yet saturated by the rains. Finally, I reached the line of the gun towers, arose to my feet, and inspected myself. My pockets, even the buttoned ones on my fatigues, were filled with mud. My boots were massive collections of muck, on the inside and the outside. The grime had found its way into my pants and through the gaps between the buttons of my shirt. Even my rifle, my M-16, which I had cleaned and cared for so religiously during the previous weeks, was fouled, the breech and barrel filled with waterlogged earth.

“I sloshed my way to the waiting truck and rode shivering back to my barracks where I made my way to the showers. With my rifle and my clothing and my filthy body, I walked in and turned on the water. There, with the warmth of clean water running over me, washing away my filth layer by layer, I began to undress, soaping and scrubbing until every trace of the scum and sludge was gone. It felt so good to be clean!

“But the accumulation of grime is not the most serious problem, provided we do not cling to it in the same way it clings to us. We are invited by the Savior to get into the showers whenever we are inclined to do so. “Wash you, make you clean; put away the evil of your doings from before mine eyes; cease to do evil.” (Isaiah 1:16.) Of course it is always the Lord who provides the water for this cleansing: “Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity,” David pled, “and cleanse me from mine sin . . . wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.” (Psalm 51:2,7.) (Ted L. Gibbons, New Testament Lesson 36: “[Beloved of God, Called to Be Saints](#),” at [LDSLiving.com](#), Sep. 04, 2015.)

†11. **Hugh Nibley:** “A righteous person is one who is repenting; a wicked person is one who is not repenting. A righteous man is not one who is all good. There is no such person at all. We have all this mixture. And a wicked man is not one who is all bad. We don't have any of either. If you are repenting, it's like being on the stairway. A person at the bottom of the stairs facing up is better off than the person at the top of the stairs facing down, if it's the way of repentance. So this is what we are told. It's never too late, and that's a marvelous thing (Hugh Nibley, *Teachings of the Book of Mormon*, Semester 1, p.113).

†12. **Saints:** “The word saint is a translation of a Greek word also rendered ‘holy,’ the fundamental idea being that of consecration or separation for a sacred purpose but since what was set apart for God must be without blemish, the word came to mean ‘free from blemish,’

whether physical or moral. In the N.T. the saints are all those who by baptism have entered into the Christian covenant.” (Bible Dictionary)

†13. **Book of Romans:** “Romans is a letter, not a treatise on gospel subjects. It is not written to the world, but to the saints, to people who already know and understand the doctrines of salvation. Paul's comments on gospel subjects presuppose an extensive prior knowledge on the part of his readers. He does not here expound doctrines as such; he simply comments about them, leaving unsaid the volumes of gospel understanding already possessed by the saints. Romans, hence is not a source of gospel knowledge for the spiritually untutored; it is not the initial place to turn to learn of Christ and his laws. In the hands of the sectarian world, Romans is a book on calculus in the hands of students who are still struggling to learn the basics of common arithmetic” (Bruce R. McConkie, *Doctrinal New Testament Commentary*, 2:211-212). (Cited in Nancy Jensen, New Testament Lesson #36 “[Beloved of God, Called to be Saints](#),” at [LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus](#), September 4, 2011.

Recommended Reading:

1. Ted L. Gibbons, New Testament Lesson 36: “[Beloved of God, Called to Be Saints](#),” at [LDSLiving.com](#), Sep. 04, 2015. Brother Gibbons tells a great story about army infantry mud.
2. Nancy Jensen, New Testament Lesson #36 “[Beloved of God, Called to be Saints](#),” at [LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus](#), September 4, 2011.
3. Lenet H. Read, [New Testament](#): NT #36 “Beloved of God, Called to Be Saints, This is an index to her PDFs. Scroll down to NT 36.
4. Gerald Smith, New Testament Gospel Doctrine Lesson 36: “[Beloved of God, Called to be Saints](#)” Romans, at Joel's Monastery, September 05, 2011.

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